



Most of It Was the Route

A cross-classified variance decomposition of practical driving-test outcomes across candidates, examiners, centres and routes

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Motivation

A practical driving test returns one verdict, recorded against the candidate alone. Centres run a fixed set of assessment routes and rotate examiners across them. How much of a first-attempt outcome belongs to the driver, and how much to the route they drew?

Objectives

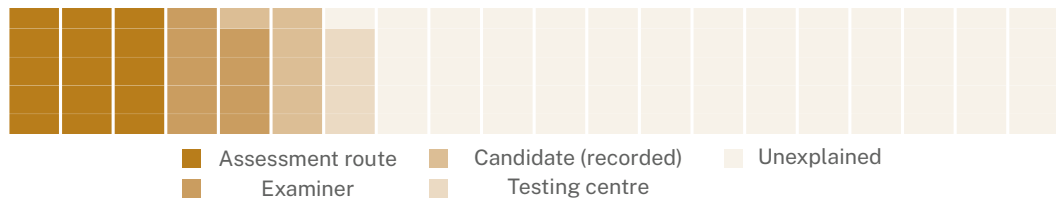
- Partition first-attempt outcome variance across candidate, examiner, centre and route
- Estimate the route component after adjustment for logged preparation and booking lead time
- Test whether a published route-difficulty adjustment changes what driving schools book

Materials & methods

- 18,704 first-attempt tests · 11 centres · 63 examiners · 41 assessment routes · 26 months
- Cross-classified logistic mixed model; candidate covariates supervised hours logged, weeks since permit, booking lead time
- Route allocated by queue position at check-in, never on request; allocation logs audited against the examiner roster for the full period

Findings

The assessment route carries more outcome variance than the examiner, and both exceed everything the record holds about the candidate. Adjusted first-attempt pass rates range from 51.3% to 78.9% across the 41 routes, and the ordering is stable across the 26 months.



Outcome variance across 18,704 first-attempt tests, January 2024 to February 2026: route 14.8%, examiner 9.3%, candidate covariates 6.1%, centre 3.8%. The route component exceeds the examiner component at all eleven centres.

Implications

A verdict recorded against one party carries a component that party did not choose. The authority now publishes a route-difficulty adjustment for reporting; schools book the lead times that draw the adjusted routes, and the next calibration is fitted to the bookings it produced.

Next: whether queue allocation survives the adjustment's second calibration cycle.

Further reading

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We thank the eleven participating testing centres. Records supplied under a data-sharing agreement and de-identified before analysis; specification and covariates pre-registered, none added after unblinding.

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“The route is one of the four things being assessed.”

Assessment route accounts for 14.8% of first-attempt outcome variance; everything the record holds about the candidate accounts for 6.1%.